



GHAJINI

The widely-publicised *Ghajini* is supposed to be an Indian 3D game for the PC. Although there are a few titles that claim the same honour, we'll give this one the benefit of doubt for what the developers have done. The game follows up on the popularity of the movie. The game has pretty high graphic requirements, and we received word from the developers about some toning down in the graphics department they had done, so that the game would run on more computers. The game puts you in the shoes of the protagonist in the film — Sanjay — and lets you play the game as his character. It is supposed to be a third-person adventure game, but it plays more like a puzzle game.

We were really impressed with the way the game begins. There are no cut scenes. Instead, you have a series of comic book-style panels that explain the background with a voice over by Aamir Khan himself, and a great background track. The game goes overboard with terms such as *darkness* and *haunting* which reads like juvenile poetry, but successfully lays down a dark and haunting aura for the game. The artwork used is amazing, and is done with style and panache. When the game loads, you are stunned by the level of detail. The environments are richly created (although with very low quality textures), and the in-game character is a very good likeness of Aamir Khan.

The game starts going downhill from the second you start playing. You get an objective in the first level — go to the lift. Sanjay, despite his amnesia (we've heard it's retrograde, but it is more highly selective than anything else), tells you that it is out of the door to his right. However, he forgets that you need keys to open the door (keys, from the inside?) so you go around the apartment looking for keys, a map of Mumbai, a camera and other oddities. You do this by opening every drawer in the map, and going over every inch of the house. You expect some action, some passion, which is why anybody would want to get in Sanjay's shoes. What you get is an escape room puzzle with zero ingenuity. The game uses some pretty good devices, which would have worked in a better game. For example, you have to hide from policemen by scanning their "cones of vision" which are shown like sweeping spotlights. Avoid the yellow areas, and they won't see you. Sanjay walks, never runs, and is even slower when crouching, which he has to do, all too often. The pace of the game is an anti-climax following the intros at every level.

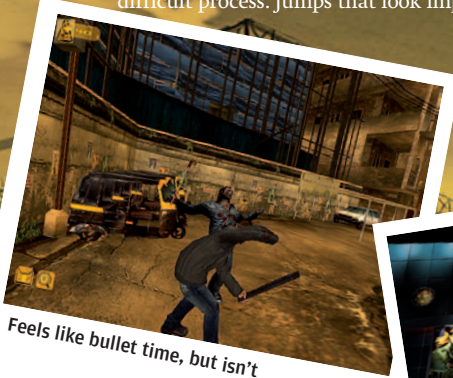
The combat does not kick in until the third level of the game. You have to beat up a construction site full of illegal drug labs. You also have to blow up the labs. The fourth level has you beating up some people in the streets of the city. Some of them have guns, but the rest use cricket bats, hockey sticks and baseball bats. Why baseball bats we wonder? There are sufficient Indian weapons around to use, a good weapon would have been the pipe with a tap still attached to it, as shown in a gory panel during the opening of the level. Navigating around the game can be a tedious and difficult process. Jumps that look impossible do no damage. Falling

from a pipe just because the control of the character is difficult kills you. Getting into doors, ramps, ledges — all of which happen pretty frequently — is made difficult by a lack of smooth programming. You are not given enough control in the game to meet the demands of the game, which is not a lack of skill on the gamer's part, but a lack of skill on the part of the developers.

The AI for the combat gets horribly boring very quickly. All the people around behave in the exact same way. There are a whole gamut of moves possible, by using a combination of the [Q] and [E] keys on the keyboard. These let you throw spectacular punches and kicks, and hardly receive any damage in the process. What is impossible to counter are the petrol bombs thrown at you every now and then. You just have to find a way to avoid them. Most of the game forces you to think of a counter-intuitive approach to a problem. If a man with a gun is shooting at you, you don't run directly at him, but approach using alternative methods out of his line of fire, so that he runs away. There are some hilarious times when you get to fight two people at a time, and they are reacting in the same way together. It feels like fighting Siamese twins who share a common brain.

There are a few moments when the meticulous attention-to-detail shines through. It is really great to see some (although boxy) autorickshaws in a game. There are a whole bunch of bugs and glitches such as disappearing floors, your head going into the surroundings, unclear areas where you cannot navigate to — all of these are forgivable. What is not forgivable, is the way the character gets stuck for no fault of yours. Jump on a tin roof in the wrong angle, your legs disappear into the floor, and you cannot move. Try climbing a pipe when you are too close to it, you are made immobile because your body becomes embedded into the pipe. These things can happen at unpredictable points in the game, and your only option is to restart. The sound is excellent, we have no complaints about it. It gives a sense of pace to what would have otherwise been a long and boring game. The graphics are better than you would have expected, and we would have accepted a lot less. The game hardly manages to tax the machine, and we have no idea why the requirements are so high. The characters look much better than the surroundings, some of which look positively alien.

What absolutely cannot be overlooked, is how unplayable the game is. This is not a game you can enjoy playing. This is not a game where your actions give you any sense of achievement. The character moves too slowly, the action is at a snail's pace, you are not allowed to run, and all of this makes the game very difficult. The game defeats you, but through no shortcomings of your own. The gameplay is simply not mature enough by international standards — prevalent a decade and a half ago. All in all, this is a very forgettable game. ■



Feels like bullet time, but isn't



Basic Instinct II rubbing shoulders with DON and Bheja Fry



Help me officer, my head is stuck in a wall